

In the middle of setting the stage in this פרשה for the dramatic and momentous עשר מצרים and יציאת מצרים, משה רבינו promises the nation that He will do everything necessary to transform Israel from a nation in servitude to a free nation. The four promises of the Exodus, and all of the promises, are contrasted with משה's counterargument: "How is פרעה going to listen to me? בני ישראל don't listen to me!" But Hashem reassures him, "פרעה will listen to you."

In the midst of all this preparation, amidst this intense unfolding of the story, the narrative suddenly pauses, and we find a פסוק by 2nd aliya. It goes through שמעון, ראובן, and לוי, detailing the lineage of לוי, including אהרן and all the family branches, and culminates with (6:26-27):

הוא אהרן ומשה אשר אמר ה' להם הוציאו את בני ישראל מארץ מצרים על צבאתם:
הם המדברים אל פרעה מלך מצרים להוציא את בני ישראל ממצרים הוא משה ואהרן:

all of the מפרשים, from ראשונים to אחרונים, address this pause in the narrative. R' Samson Raphael Hirsch makes a poignant point. He emphasizes that משה and אהרן, as great as they were, were people. They were not beings from another planet or supernatural entities. They were not gods, as other religions often portray their heroes. The flip side is that these individuals came with a יחוס. As R' Samson Raphael Hirsch says, these were not lunatics claiming, "I am a משיח, I will save you!" Rather, they were individuals of great יחוס and סגולות, holy and good people, with the qualifications to be מנהיגי ישראל and מושיעים of ישראל.

However, פסוק כ"ז begins with הוא אהרן ומשה, while פסוק כ"ח concludes with הוא משה ואהרן. Why is the פסוק repeating itself? Yes, we know the idea that the pasuk switched the order of their names to indicate that משה and אהרן were שווים, equal in stature, though משה was the מנהיג. Despite this, they regarded one another as equals. That explains the order reversal. But why the פסוק repeats itself still requires explanation.

The פסוק offers a tremendous insight, providing a מוסר השכל for us. The פסוק says: הוא אהרן ומשה; then it pauses and continues: הם המדברים אל פרעה מלך מצרים. Finally, it ends with הוא משה ואהרן. The פסוק explains that the first part, הוא אהרן ומשה, highlights their lineage and the קדושה they achieved. These were individuals of קדושה עליונה, which they reached through their own efforts, not because they were God-made or supernatural beings. The next section, הם המדברים אל פרעה, emphasizes their active role. They spent long periods speaking with פרעה, in constant contact with the טומאה of מצרים. Yet, despite this prolonged exposure, the פסוק informs us - הוא משה ואהרן - the קדושה of משה and אהרן remained completely unaffected. Not even a hairbreadth. The קדושה of משה and אהרן remained exactly the same, that the טומאה of פרעה had zero effect on them.

This teaches us a critical lesson. Even when engaging with טומאה or challenges, through careful effort and vigilance, we can maintain our level of קדושה without compromise. We live in a time of deal making - "give a little, get a little." While compromise may be acceptable in some areas of life, it has no place when it comes to our יסודות. True leaders like מרדכי in פורים and משה in מתתיהו never wavered in their principles. The same applies to all the great leaders of Israel throughout history, and even in our time, R' Yosef Chaim Sonnenfeld was bitterly criticized by the other members of the anti-dתי, but even the דתי, to "give a little bit", but he refused to compromise any one of his principles.

We have to learn from this. When it comes to our principles, we don't compromise. We try to give in a little in other things in life, but not when it comes to our principles. We see certain parts of our religious experience where people try to cut corners a little bit. They daven a little faster, they come a little bit later; they don't wear the things that we used to wear. Some people accept that, and say we have to look away, we have to be accepting of everyone, and there's a point to קירוב. However, we have to not compromise



our principles. On סוכות we take the ארבע מינים: לולב, אתרוג, הדסים and ערבות. Three are kept together, the לולב, הדסים and ערבות, but the אתרוג is kept separate from the other three in its own box. When we do the מצוה, we take all four together. But when we're not doing the מצוה, we keep it separate. We must keep our principles untarnished and uncompromised. We want to make sure that we know what we're talking about and what we stand for, for our דור דורות, our children and our grandchildren, so that we can continue our סגולות, our ישועות, and our שלשלת until בימינו אמן!

